

The Corbiani Almanac

MARCH 29 - APRIL 4, 2026

Cherry Blossoms, Open Doors & the Road to Cleveland

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 03/29 SUNNY 62°/30°	Cherry blossom visit at the Tidal Basin	Sausage & Gravy with Pasta	Stevie Wonder – Songs in the Key of Life
Mon 03/30 RAIN 73°/50°	House viewing at 4:00 PM; MTP Sovereign Staff Meeting 4:10-5:00 PM	Babo Pasta	Silk Sonic – An Evening with Silk Sonic
Tue 03/31 SUNNY 79°/59°	1:1 meetings 2:50-4:30 PM; Elsie's Level 4 Swim Lessons 6:00-6:30 PM (2310 Colts Neck Rd, Reston)	Grilled Chicken	Jungle – Loving in Stereo
Wed 04/01 RAIN 81°/61°	Relaxed day; 1:1 Suhani 9:20 AM	Pizza	Parliament – Mothership Connection
Thu 04/02 LIGHT DRIZZLE 82°/63°	House viewing #2; Free day (Spring Break)	Waffles	Prince – Sign 'O' the Times
Fri 04/03 LIGHT DRIZZLE 77°/64°	Flying to Cleveland!; Dinner at Good Pizza (2057 E 4th St, Cleveland, OH 44115) – open Fri 11 AM–10 PM, (216) 400-9333	Good Pizza (Cleveland)	The Soul Rebels – Poetry in Motion
Sat 04/04 LIGHT DRIZZLE 80°/62°	Exploring Cleveland!; Dinner at Savage Burger (4259 Fulton Rd, Cleveland, OH 44144) – open Sat 11 AM–12 AM, (216) 415-5114	Savage Burger (Cleveland)	Kaytranada – BUBBA

Daily Plan

*From Italian-American to American Smash Burgers, with Stevie Wonder on
the stereo*

Sunday, March 29

CHERRY BLOSSOM VISIT AT THE TIDAL BASIN

Sausage & Gravy with Pasta

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Classic Italian-American Sunday gravy with sausage over pasta — the kind of slow-simmered tomato sauce that fills the house with warmth on a cool spring evening.

Italian sausage, crushed tomatoes, garlic, basil, red pepper flakes, pasta, Parmesan

AT THE TABLE

We saw all those cherry blossoms today — they only last about two weeks and then they're gone. If you could keep one moment from today and put it in a jar on your shelf forever, which moment would you pick?

Cherry blossoms are a real-world lesson in impermanence, and eight-year-olds are just beginning to grasp that beautiful things don't last forever. This question helps Elsie practice savoring — identifying what mattered most in a full day — which builds both gratitude and emotional vocabulary.

STRATEGIC THINKING

Definite Thinking: The Courage to Commit to a Specific Future

In a culture that worships optionality, the most powerful move is the opposite — choosing one concrete future and building toward it with everything you have.

"A definite view favors firm convictions. Instead of pursuing many-sided mediocrity and calling it well-roundedness, a definite person determines the one best thing to do and then does it."

— Peter Thiel, *Zero to One* Ch. 6

You Are Not a Lottery Ticket

You walked through the cherry blossoms this morning — a tunnel of pale pink that won't last the week. Here's something worth sitting with: that tree didn't keep its options open. It spent eleven months banking energy into roots and branches, then committed everything to a single, extravagant burst of bloom. No Plan B. No diversification strategy. No waiting for better conditions. It picked its moment and went all in. Most of us live the opposite way. We keep our schedules flexible, our career options open, our home search permanently "exploratory." We call this being smart. Peter Thiel has a sharper word for it: indefinite. In Chapter 6 of *Zero to One*, he draws a distinction that should unsettle anyone who prizes optionality. He describes four worldviews along two axes — optimism versus pessimism, and definite versus indefinite. The dangerous quadrant isn't pessimism. It's indefinite optimism — the belief that things will probably get better, but without any specific plan for how. "Instead of working toward a singular and substantive goal," Thiel writes, indefinite optimists "just chase short-term luck" (*Zero to One*, Ch. 6). That's the person who says "I'm sure we'll find the right house eventually" but hasn't defined what "right" actually means. It's the couple who browses listings for months, always finding one more flaw, one more reason to wait.

Definite optimism works differently. It says: I believe the future will be better because I'm going to make it better — and here is the specific plan. The definite optimist doesn't just hope for a good neighborhood and solid schools; she identifies the exact streets, the exact trade-offs she'll accept, and the exact price at which the math works. She's not reckless — she's resolved. The distinction matters because indefinite thinking feels safe but carries hidden costs. Every month spent "just looking" is a month of rising prices, deferred rootedness, another season your kid doesn't have that backyard. Optionality has a price tag, and it's usually paid in time you can't get back. Thiel's chapter title is itself the argument: "You Are Not a Lottery Ticket." Your life isn't a series of random draws. You have agency — the question is whether you'll use it to design a specific future or spend it shuffling between comfortable maybes. This week, we'll pull that thread across seven days, exploring what it means to think definitely about the choices that shape your life. The cherry blossoms are here for just a few days. What are you ready to bloom toward?

"Instead of working toward a singular and substantive goal, indefinite optimists just chase short-term luck."

— Peter Thiel, *Zero to One* Ch. 6

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Red Wine Fond Build — Sear sausages in a screaming-hot cast-iron or Dutch oven until deeply browned on all sides — we're talking mahogany, not beige. Remove the sausages, drop the heat to medium, and pour in half a cup of...

ACID Gremolata Finish — Right before plating, make a quick gremolata: finely mince 1 clove of raw garlic, zest one lemon on a Microplane, and chiffonade a big handful of flat-leaf Italian parsley. Combine. Scatter a generous...

TEXTURE Pangrattato (Toasted Garlic Breadcrumbs) — Tear day-old bread into rough crumbs (or pulse in a food processor — not too fine). Heat 3 tablespoons of olive oil in a skillet over medium heat, add the breadcrumbs with 2 minced garlic cloves and ...

PREPARATION Finish Pasta in the Sauce — Cook your pasta 2 full minutes short of the package time — it should be bendy but have a visible white core when you bite it in half. Reserve a full cup of starchy pasta water before draining. Transf...

STEVIE WONDER

Songs in the Key of Life

1976 · SOUL / FUNK / POP · JOYOUS,
SPIRITUAL, WARM, PROFOUND,
CELEBRATORY

Widely considered the greatest album ever made. A sprawling, joyous masterwork that covers love, justice, spirituality,...

Sunday comfort food deserves the warmest album ever made. Stevie's soulful grooves are the musical equivalent of sausage gravy — rich, satisfying, and universally loved.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Monday, March 30

4:00 PM	HOUSE VIEWING AT
4:10-5:00 PM	MTP SOVEREIGN STAFF MEETING

Babo Pasta

ITALIAN

Intimate homemade pasta night — a simple, elegant Italian dish that lets the ingredients shine. Perfect for a cozy evening after a big day of house viewing.

pasta, garlic, olive oil, Parmesan, fresh herbs, butter

AT THE TABLE

So we looked at that house today. If you got to design your own room in a brand-new house — any color walls, any kind of furniture, anything on the ceiling — what would it look like? Walk us through it like you're giving us a tour.

Visiting a potential new home can stir up a tangle of excitement and anxiety. Giving Elsie the imaginative power to design her own space transforms the uncertainty into creative agency. At eight, having a say — even a fantastical one — makes transitions feel less like something happening to her and more like something she's helping build.

The Forty-Seventh Open House

Picture a couple who's been house-hunting for six months. They've toured forty-seven homes. They've built a spreadsheet with columns for natural light, commute time, school ratings, basement ceiling height, and "vibe." Each new listing triggers a fresh round of comparisons. They aren't getting closer to a decision — they're getting better at evaluating, which is not the same thing. This is the most common disguise procrastination wears when the stakes are high: it dresses up as diligence. You're not avoiding the decision, you tell yourself. You're being thorough. Annie Duke, a former professional poker player turned decision scientist, diagnoses the problem precisely in *Thinking in Bets*: "What makes a decision great is not that it has a great outcome. A great decision is the result of a good process, and that process must include an attempt to accurately represent our own state of knowledge. That state of knowledge, in turn, is some variation of 'I'm not sure'" (*Thinking in Bets*, Ch. 1). The insight cuts both ways. Yes, you should acknowledge uncertainty. But Duke's point is that once you've honestly assessed what you know and what you don't, the decision is ready to be made — not after one more open house, one more inspection report, one more opinion from your brother-in-law.

The forty-seventh house won't tell you something the first thirty didn't. At some point, additional information isn't reducing uncertainty — it's feeding a different hunger entirely. It's feeding the need to feel certain before you act, which, in a world of imperfect information, is a need that can never be satisfied. Peter Thiel puts the cost plainly: indefinite thinkers "don't have any specific plans for the future, so they just try to assemble a diverse portfolio of options" (*Zero to One*, Ch. 6). Applied to house-hunting, that means visiting every neighborhood, reading every market analysis, and never making an offer — because the perfect listing might appear next week. The definite thinker takes a different approach. She defines her criteria up front, searches within those boundaries, and when a house meets the bar she's already set, she acts. She doesn't confuse the anxiety of commitment with the absence of readiness. Readiness isn't a feeling that descends on you like grace. It's a standard you set in advance and honor when the moment arrives. If your spreadsheet has more than ten columns, the spreadsheet isn't helping anymore. It's hiding.

"What makes a decision great is not that it has a great outcome. A great decision is the result of a good process."

— Annie Duke, *Thinking in Bets* Ch. 1

Reflect: When was the last time "doing more research" was actually a way of avoiding a decision you already had enough information to make?

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE Brown Butter & Crispy Sage — Cut 4 tablespoons of unsalted butter into pieces and place in a light-colored skillet over medium heat (you need to see the color change). Swirl occasionally. When the foam subsides and the milk soli...

TEXTURE Toasted Pine Nuts — Toast 3 tablespoons of pine nuts in a dry skillet over medium-low heat, shaking the pan every 20 seconds. The moment they turn golden and you smell that sweet, nutty aroma — pull them off the heat an...

ACID Microplaned Lemon Zest — After plating, take a Microplane and zest fresh lemon directly over each serving — about 5-6 passes per plate. Use only the bright yellow outer layer, never the white pith. Do this at the table if yo...

SILK SONIC

An Evening with Silk Sonic

2021 · RETRO SOUL / FUNK · SMOOTH,
FLIRTATIOUS, WARM, PLAYFUL, NOSTALGIC

Bruno Mars and Anderson .Paak's retro-soul love letter is pure dinner-table gold — every track is a singalong waiting t...

Intimate Italian pasta calls for smooth, flirtatious grooves. Silk Sonic's velvet harmonies are the perfect soundtrack for a quiet evening at home.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Tuesday, March 31

2:50-4:30 PM	1:1 MEETINGS
6:00-6:30 PM	ELSIE'S LEVEL 4 SWIM LESSONS

Grilled Chicken

AMERICAN

Simple grilled chicken — the first real spring grilling day with sunshine and 79°F. Quick and easy before swim lessons.

chicken breasts or thighs, olive oil, lemon, garlic, herbs, salt, pepper

AT THE TABLE

You had swim lessons today. What's something in the water that felt really hard at first but is starting to feel a little easier? Is there anything like that outside the pool, too?

This bridges the physical and emotional — research shows kids build confidence by recognizing their own progress. Asking her to connect a pool skill to something in her wider life builds metacognition: she's not just learning to swim, she's learning that she's someone who can get better at hard things.

Four Futures on a Napkin

Grab a napkin and draw a cross — optimism on top, pessimism on the bottom, definite on the left, indefinite on the right. You now have Peter Thiel's most useful mental model, and it takes about four seconds to explain at a dinner table. The definite pessimist believes the future will be grim and plans accordingly — think of someone building a six-month emergency fund or a country stockpiling grain reserves. It sounds depressing, but there's dignity in it: at least the definite pessimist has a plan. The indefinite pessimist has given up entirely — the future looks bad and there's nothing to be done about it. The indefinite optimist is the most common species in comfortable societies: things will probably work out, somehow, eventually. No need for a specific plan. Just stay in school, get good grades, keep your options open, and trust the process. Thiel's argument in Chapter 6 of *Zero to One* is that this quadrant — indefinite optimism — has quietly become the default operating system for an entire generation. "A definite view, by contrast, favors firm convictions," he writes. "Instead of pursuing many-sided mediocrity and calling it 'well-roundedness,' a definite person determines the one best thing to do and then does it" (*Zero to One*, Ch. 6).

The quadrant that interests us this week is the upper left: definite optimism. This is the person who believes the future will be better and has drawn up the blueprints to prove it. It's the family that says, "We want a house with a yard big enough for a garden, within fifteen minutes of school, and we'll stretch our budget by exactly this much and no further." No hedging, no endless browsing — a concrete vision with specific constraints. Here's the uncomfortable part: living in the definite-optimist quadrant requires exposure. You have to name what you want, which means admitting it might not work out. The indefinite optimist never faces that risk because she never commits to a specific outcome. She can always say, "Well, I was keeping my options open." But options without a thesis are just drift with better branding. Try this exercise tonight. Pick any decision your family is currently weighing — the house, a vacation, a change in routine — and locate it on the napkin. Ask each person at the table where they think the family falls. You might discover that you and your partner are living in different quadrants entirely, which explains a lot of dinner-table friction. The napkin doesn't solve the decision. But it makes the real disagreement visible, and visible disagreements are the only kind you can actually resolve.

"Instead of pursuing many-sided mediocrity and calling it well-roundedness, a definite person determines the one best thing to do and then does it."

— Peter Thiel, *Zero to One* Ch. 6

Reflect: Draw the napkin tonight. Which quadrant describes how you've been approaching your biggest current decision — and which quadrant do you want to be in?

CHEF'S TIPS

MARINADE 24-Hour Dry Brine — The night before: pat chicken pieces (bone-in, skin-on thighs are best for this) completely dry with paper towels. Mix together 1 tablespoon kosher salt, 1 teaspoon sugar, 1 teaspoon smoked paprika, ...

SAUCE Chimichurri Board Sauce — Make chimichurri: finely mince 1 cup flat-leaf parsley, ½ cup fresh cilantro, 4 garlic cloves, and 1 small shallot. Combine with ½ cup good olive oil, 3 tablespoons red wine vinegar, ½ teaspoon red p...

TEMPERATURE Quick-Pickled Red Onions — Slice 1 large red onion into thin rings. In a jar, combine ½ cup rice vinegar, 2 tablespoons sugar, 1 teaspoon salt, and ½ cup warm water. Stir to dissolve. Pack the onions in, making sure they're su...

PREPARATION Leftover Strategy: Grill Smart, Store Smarter — Grill extra bone-in, skin-on thighs alongside your dinner pieces. Pull all chicken at 160°F internal (not 165°F — carryover heat will take it there during rest). Rest the dinner chicken for 10 minute...

J U N G L E

Loving in Stereo

2021 · MODERN DISCO-FUNK · EUPHORIC,
SUN-DRENCHED, OPTIMISTIC, DANCEABLE

Modern soul-funk collective from London. Jungle delivers danceable joy with sonic sophistication — the sound of steppin...

Sunny 79°F grilling weather meets sun-drenched disco-funk. Jungle's breezy optimism is the sound of spring finally arriving.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Wednesday, April 1

9:20 AM

RELAXED DAY
1:1 SUHANI

Pizza

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Homemade pizza night — everyone picks their toppings. A relaxed midweek dinner for the warmest day of the week so far.

pizza dough, mozzarella, tomato sauce, toppings of choice, olive oil, basil

AT THE TABLE

It's the middle of spring break and we have nowhere to be tomorrow. If the three of us had to create a brand-new family holiday — a holiday that only our family celebrates — what would it be called and what would the traditions be?

Midweek of a break is the sweet spot: the rush of the beginning has settled, and the end isn't looming yet. This question invites Elsie to define what makes your family unique — a powerful exercise at an age when she's starting to compare her family to others. It also tells her: our traditions are ours to invent.

The Cost of Let Me Think About It

Here's a scene that plays out in every household facing a big decision. One partner comes home energized from a house tour: "This is the one — the yard, the kitchen, the street. I can see us there." The other partner pauses. "Let me think about it." Perfectly reasonable. Except three days later, they're still thinking about it. And the first partner's excitement has curdled into something heavier — not anger exactly, but the slow drain of carrying enthusiasm alone. Indecision between two people is never neutral. When one person holds the pause button, the other absorbs the weight of uncertainty. The decision doesn't hover politely in midair; it lands on someone, usually the person who's already made up their mind and is now waiting, recalibrating, wondering whether their judgment is trusted. Brené Brown captures the dynamic in *Dare to Lead*: "Choosing courage over comfort is not always our default. Staying brave is a practice" (*Dare to Lead*, Part 1). Making a definite commitment — saying "yes, this house" or "no, not this one" — is an act of vulnerability. You're exposing your judgment to reality, where it can be proven wrong.

That exposure is precisely why people stall. "Let me think about it" sometimes means "I need more data," but it often means "I'm not ready to be responsible for this choice." The antidote isn't pressure. It's naming the real fear and addressing it directly. "I'm worried about the commute" is a conversation. "Let me think about it" is a door left ajar that lets the cold air in. Thiel's framework helps here too. When one partner operates as a definite optimist and the other as an indefinite one, they aren't just disagreeing about a house — they're disagreeing about how the future works. One believes you can design a specific life. The other is waiting for a certainty that will never arrive. Bridging that gap requires something more honest than another spreadsheet column. It requires sitting across from each other and saying, "Here's what I'm afraid of, and here's what I want anyway." Definite thinking in a relationship doesn't mean one person steamrolls the other. It means both people name their vision out loud, compare the blueprints, and build something specific together — even when the math is uncomfortable and the answer isn't perfect. The strongest commitments aren't made in the absence of doubt. They're made in the presence of it, by two people who decided that clarity matters more than comfort.

"Choosing courage over comfort is not always our default. Staying brave is a practice."

— Brené Brown, *Dare to Lead* Part 1

Reflect: Is there a decision you've been answering with "let me think about it" — and if you're honest, is the thinking really about the decision, or about the vulnerability of committing?

PARLIAMENT

Mothership Connection

1975 · P-FUNK · EUPHORIC, COSMIC,
ABSURDIST, CELEBRATORY

George Clinton's P-Funk motherlode. Sci-fi funk mythology, some of the heaviest grooves ever recorded, and lyrics that'...

*Pizza night is casual and fun — Parliament brings the cosmic party energy.
Bootsy's bass is the perfect soundtrack for rolling dough and arguing about toppings.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Thursday, April 2

HOUSE VIEWING #2

FREE DAY

Waffles

AMERICAN

Breakfast for dinner! Crispy waffles with all the fixings. Another house viewing today keeps the excitement building — waffles are the perfect low-effort reward after a big day.

waffle batter, eggs, butter, maple syrup, fresh berries, whipped cream

AT THE TABLE

We're having breakfast for dinner! What other rules do you think would be fun to flip upside down for a day? Bedtime at noon? Parents go to school and kids go to work? What would your upside-down day look like?

Breakfast-for-dinner is delightful precisely because it breaks a rule, and eight-year-olds are deep in the process of understanding which rules matter and which are just habits. This question lets Elsie play with rule-breaking safely, building her sense of humor and her moral reasoning at the same time.

Walking Through the One-Way Door

Tomorrow you're looking at a house. Not browsing — looking, with intent. So let's talk about doors. Jeff Bezos sorts every decision into one of two categories. Type 1 decisions are one-way doors: "consequential and irreversible or nearly irreversible," he wrote in his 2015 letter to Amazon shareholders. "If you walk through and don't like what you see on the other side, you can't get back to where you were before." Type 2 decisions are two-way doors — reversible, low-cost, easy to undo. Bezos's key insight is that most organizations — and most families — treat every decision like a one-way door, applying heavyweight deliberation to choices that could easily be reversed. The result, he warns, is "slowness, unthoughtful risk aversion, failure to experiment sufficiently, and consequently diminished invention" (2015 Amazon Shareholder Letter). But buying a house? That is a genuine one-way door. You're committing several hundred thousand dollars, a geographic anchor, a neighborhood, a commute, a set of neighbors, a school district. You can sell later, but the transaction costs — financial, emotional, logistical — are enormous. This is exactly the kind of choice that deserves slow, careful, definite treatment.

So here's a practical framework for Monday's house visit. First, separate the reversible from the irreversible. The paint color is a two-way door — change it next weekend. The floor plan is mostly a one-way door — you'll live with that layout for years. The neighborhood is almost entirely irreversible without moving again. Second, apply Thiel's definite optimism specifically to the one-way elements. Don't hope the neighborhood improves — research it. Don't assume the commute will be manageable — drive it at rush hour on a Tuesday. Don't tell yourself you'll renovate the kitchen "someday" — either the house works at the price you're paying, or it doesn't. Third — and this is where most people flinch — set a decision deadline before you walk through the front door. Not "we'll see how we feel" but "if this house meets our seven criteria, we make an offer by Wednesday." The deadline isn't arbitrary pressure. It's the structural commitment that prevents indefinite optimism from consuming another month. One-way doors deserve deliberation. But deliberation has a finish line. Walk through the door with your eyes open and your criteria clear, and the door you chose becomes the foundation, not the trap.

"Some decisions are consequential and irreversible or nearly irreversible — one-way doors — and these decisions must be made methodically, carefully, slowly, with great deliberation."

— Jeff Bezos, 2015 Amazon Shareholder Letter

Reflect: For the biggest decision you're facing right now, which elements are truly one-way doors — and which have you been treating as irreversible when they're actually easy to change?

PRINCE

Sign 'O' the Times

1987 · FUNK / ROCK / POP / SOUL ·
ECLECTIC, PASSIONATE, FUNKY, SOCIALLY
AWARE, JOYFUL

Prince's double-album masterpiece — 80 minutes of funk, rock, soul,
and pop from the most prolific genius in music hist...

*Breakfast for dinner is gloriously eclectic — just like Prince. His joyful party energy
('Housequake') matches the playful chaos of waffles at dinnertime.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Friday, April 3

FLYING TO CLEVELAND!
DINNER AT GOOD PIZZA— OPEN FRI 11 AM–10 PM, 400-9333

Good Pizza (Cleveland)

NY-STYLE PIZZA

Flying to Cleveland! Dinner at Good Pizza — NY-style slices on E 4th Street. The Spicy Vodka pie (\$26) is the hit, plus Margherita (\$24) and Pepperoni with hot honey (\$28). Casual, 4.8★, open till 10 PM. Don't skip the Cheesy Bread Loaf (\$14.85) and Classic Tiramisu (\$5.85).

The Story: Good Pizza started as a pandemic passion project. Founder Charlie Anderson began posting meticulous New York-style pizza tutorials on YouTube in 2019, building a following of over 170,000 subscribers who watched him obsess over dough hydration, sauce ratios, and oven technique. That online momentum fueled a series of wildly popular pop-ups at Bookhouse Brewing and Edda Coffee around Cleveland. By early 2025, Anderson opened his brick-and-mortar on the vibrant East 4th Street corridor, taking over the former Citizen Pie Roman Café space. Inspired by iconic New York spots like Scarr's and Mama's TOO!, the menu is intentionally tight — just five core slices plus a seasonal rotation — so every pie gets obsessive attention. It's a story of digital-age entrepreneurship meeting old-school craft, and Cleveland embraced it immediately.

Spicy Vodka pie, Margherita, Pepperoni with hot honey, Cheesy Bread Loaf, Classic Tiramisu

AT THE TABLE

We just flew to a whole new city! When you stepped off the plane and looked around, what was the first thing you noticed that was different from home? And what was the first thing that felt the same?

Travel sharpens observation — kids who are asked to notice details become better at reading new environments. The 'different AND same' structure teaches Elsie that new places aren't all-or-nothing scary; there's always something familiar to anchor to. This builds adaptability, a skill she'll use every time she walks into a new classroom, team, or friendship.

In Praise of the Open Door

Every good idea has a shadow, and definite thinking is no exception. Spend a week celebrating commitment and conviction, and you owe it to yourself to ask the uncomfortable question: what if staying open is sometimes the smarter play? Charlie Munger, who spent sixty years making definite bets alongside Warren Buffett, would be the first to warn you. His most famous piece of advice isn't about committing harder — it's about inverting the question entirely. "Invert, always invert," Munger repeats, borrowing from the mathematician Carl Jacobi. "Many hard problems are best solved when they are addressed backward" (Poor Charlie's Almanack, Ch. 2). Instead of asking "should we buy this house?" the inversion asks: "What would make buying this house a disaster?" Instead of listing reasons to commit, you list the conditions under which commitment would be ruinous — overpaying in a cooling market, locking into a thirty-year mortgage before a career shift, choosing a neighborhood that feels right in cherry-blossom season but isolates you by November.

The value of this exercise is that it doesn't replace definite thinking — it stress-tests it. Commitment without scrutiny is just stubbornness wearing ambition's clothes. There are real situations where keeping options open is the highest-value strategy. When the information environment is genuinely shifting — interest rates are volatile, your career situation is evolving, the housing market is in flux — the cost of waiting can be lower than the cost of locking into a bad position. The key distinction is making that openness a definite choice, not a drift. There's a world of difference between "I'm choosing not to decide this month because rates may drop and our lease runs through September" and "I just can't pull the trigger." The first is strategic patience with a timeline. The second is indefinite optimism in disguise. Munger's inversion gives you a practical litmus test: if you've honestly listed the ways this commitment could fail and none of them are likely or catastrophic, your hesitation isn't caution — it's comfort avoidance. But if the inversion surfaces a genuine risk you hadn't addressed, that's not cold feet. That's intelligence. The strongest version of definite thinking isn't blind commitment. It's commitment that has survived the inversion — a conviction that looked its own worst-case scenario in the eye and decided to proceed anyway, with a plan for what to do if the floor shifts.

"Invert, always invert. Many hard problems are best solved when they are addressed backward."

— Charlie Munger, Poor Charlie's Almanack Ch. 2

Reflect: Take the decision you're most committed to right now and invert it: what would make this choice a disaster? Have you addressed those risks, or just hoped they wouldn't materialize?

THE SOUL REBELS

Poetry in Motion

2019 · BRASS FUNK / HIP-HOP · JUBILANT,
ENERGETIC, CELEBRATORY, DEFIANT JOY

New Orleans brass band that fuses hip-hop, funk, and soul into a high-energy brass party. Playing the 9:30 Club this we...

Travel day energy needs a brass band. The Soul Rebels' jubilant New Orleans funk is the perfect soundtrack for landing in a new city and hunting down great pizza.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Saturday, April 4

EXPLORING CLEVELAND!
DINNER AT SAVAGE BURGER— OPEN SAT 11 AM–12 AM, 415-5114

Savage Burger (Cleveland)

AMERICAN SMASH BURGERS

Exploring Cleveland! Dinner at Savage Burger — legendary smash burgers with Cajun fries and signature "savage sauce." Try the Classic Savage, Hawaiian Savage, or Super Savage. Open till midnight. Beyond Burger available for plant-based option.

The Story: Savage Burger is a Cleveland neighborhood original on Fulton Road, built on the idea that a great burger doesn't need a corporate playbook — just bold seasoning, crispy edges, and a secret "savage sauce" that regulars can't stop talking about. The kitchen leans on a home-style approach with a signature spice blend that reviewers describe as "grandmother's cooking with a punch." What started as a single storefront has grown into multiple locations across Shaker Heights, South Euclid, Euclid, and Maple Heights — a testament to Cleveland's appetite for independently owned spots that prioritize flavor over flash. Beyond burgers, the menu stretches to shrimp, salmon, and chicken plates, but it's the Classic Savage with Cajun fries that put this place on the map. It's the kind of joint where the line out the door is the only review you need.

Classic Savage Burger, Super Savage, Cajun fries, Savage Fries, savage sauce, tater tots

AT THE TABLE

We've been exploring Cleveland all day. If you were writing a travel guide for other kids visiting this city, what would be your number-one must-do recommendation and your one 'skip it' warning?

Asking Elsie to be the expert — the guide, the reviewer — flips the usual parent-child dynamic. At eight, she craves competence and being taken seriously. Framing her opinions as advice for other kids validates her perspective and builds critical thinking: she has to evaluate, rank, and justify her experience.

The Bloom and the Roots

A week ago you stood under the cherry blossoms and watched petals drift like snow that chose to be pink. Today, walking the same path, the blooms are already thinning. In a few days the branches will be bare again, which is exactly the point — the tree isn't wasting time regretting the bloom or wondering whether it should have held back. It's already redirecting energy to its roots, preparing for next year's definite commitment. That's the image worth carrying out of this week: definite thinking isn't a single dramatic leap. It's a cycle — commit, execute, learn, recommit. Peter Thiel's framework in *Zero to One* gives you the diagnosis: most people live in indefinite optimism, drifting on vague hopes without specific plans. Annie Duke reminds you that great decisions are about process quality, not outcome guarantees. Bezos teaches you to sort your choices by reversibility. Munger insists you invert before you commit. And Brown names the real obstacle: the vulnerability of saying “this is what I want” when you know you might be wrong.

But principles don't survive the week unless you build them into something structural. So here's what carrying definite thinking forward actually looks like. First, adopt the napkin test as a household habit. When a decision stalls, grab a piece of paper, draw the four quadrants, and locate yourselves honestly. Are you being definite or indefinite? Optimistic or pessimistic? Making the framework visible makes the drift visible too. Second, practice Munger's inversion on any commitment that costs more than you'd want to lose. Before you say yes to the house, the job, the school — name three ways it could go wrong and confirm you've addressed each one. If you have, commit without apology. Third, set deadlines for open questions. Not artificial urgency, but a specific date by which the decision will be made. Indefinite optimism dies the moment you write a date on the calendar. Thiel writes that “you are not a lottery ticket” (*Zero to One*, Ch. 6), and the simplest proof of that belief is acting like it — choosing a future on purpose rather than waiting for one to arrive. The cherry tree doesn't bloom tentatively. It doesn't send out half its petals to test the market. It blooms completely because the work was already done in the dark — months of root growth, nutrient storage, and patient preparation that nobody sees. Your definite commitments work the same way. The visible leap is only possible because of the invisible preparation. Prepare honestly, invert relentlessly, and when the moment arrives, bloom.

“You are not a lottery ticket.”

— Peter Thiel, *Zero to One* Ch. 6

Reflect: What is one definite commitment you will make before this day ends — not because you have perfect information, but because you've done the work and you're ready?

You are not a lottery ticket. Prepare honestly, invert relentlessly, and when your moment arrives, bloom.

KAYTRANADA

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Haitian-Canadian producer who makes house music that bumps and grooves like nothing else. A dinner party staple that br...

Exploring a new city at night calls for groovy, nocturnal beats. Kaytranada's sophisticated cool matches the adventure of discovering Cleveland's best smash burgers.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, and beverages

Appetizers

Whipped Feta Dip with Roasted Spring Radishes & Honey

Creamy whipped feta served with honey-roasted radishes and warm pita

Vietnamese Fresh Spring Rolls with Peanut-Hoisin Dipping Sauce

Rice paper rolls with shrimp, herbs, vermicelli, and peanut dipping sauce

Salads

TOSSED DINNER

Green Goddess Salad with Herbs & Cashew Dressing

Hearty tossed salad with green goddess dressing made from herbs and cashews

Dressing: Green goddess dressing with avocado, herbs, lemon

COMPOSED DINNER

Spring Niçoise Salad with Seared Tuna, Asparagus & Radishes

Classic composed salad with seared tuna, eggs, olives, potatoes, asparagus, and radishes

Dressing: Dijon vinaigrette

SIDE

Shaved Asparagus & Pea Shoot Salad with Lemon-Parmesan Vinaigrette

Raw shaved asparagus and pea shoots with lemon, Parmesan, and olive oil

Dressing: Lemon-Parmesan vinaigrette

SIDE

Quick-Pickled Radish & Cucumber Salad with Sesame-Ginger Dressing

Quick-pickled radishes and cucumbers with sesame and rice vinegar

Dressing: Rice vinegar sesame-ginger dressing

Beverage Pairings

Albariño (Rías Baixas White Wine)

Crisp Spanish white wine — citrus and stone fruit

Hefeweizen (Bavarian Wheat Beer)

German wheat beer — banana and clove notes

Cucumber-Mint Agua Fresca

Refreshing non-alcoholic cooler with cucumber, mint, and lime

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Parenting Corner

Every Door Is a Story

This week is full of doorways — the front door of a house that might become home, the gate at the airport, the entrance to a restaurant in a city you've never explored together. Spring break means Elsie is beside you for all of it: cherry blossoms that bloom and fall in a single week, the thrill of imagining a new room, the buzz of a first flight to somewhere new. At eight, she's old enough to feel the electricity of change but still young enough to need you to name it. So name it. Every door you walk through this week is a story waiting to start. Let her open a few of them first.

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — SAUSAGE & GRAVY PASTA

"We saw all those cherry blossoms today — they only last about two weeks and then they're gone. If you could keep one moment from today and put it in a jar on your shelf forever, which moment would you pick?"

Cherry blossoms are a real-world lesson in impermanence, and eight-year-olds are just beginning to grasp that beautiful things don't last forever. This question helps Elsie practice savoring — identifying what mattered most in a full day — which builds both gratitude and emotional vocabulary.

MONDAY — BABO PASTA

"So we looked at that house today. If you got to design your own room in a brand-new house — any color walls, any kind of furniture, anything on the ceiling — what would it look like? Walk us through it like you're giving us a tour."

Visiting a potential new home can stir up a tangle of excitement and anxiety. Giving Elsie the imaginative power to design her own space transforms the uncertainty into creative agency. At eight, having a say — even a fantastical one — makes transitions feel less like something happening to her and more like something she's helping build.

TUESDAY — GRILLED CHICKEN

"You had swim lessons today. What's something in the water that felt really hard at first but is starting to feel a little easier? Is there anything like that outside the pool, too?"

This bridges the physical and emotional — research shows kids build confidence by recognizing their own progress. Asking her to connect a pool skill to something in her wider life builds metacognition: she's not just learning to swim, she's learning that she's someone who can get better at hard things.

WEDNESDAY — PIZZA

"It's the middle of spring break and we have nowhere to be tomorrow. If the three of us had to create a brand-new family holiday — a holiday that only our family celebrates — what would it be called and what would the traditions be?"

Midweek of a break is the sweet spot: the rush of the beginning has settled, and the end isn't looming yet. This question invites Elsie to define what makes your family unique — a powerful exercise at an age when she's starting to compare her family to others. It also tells her: our traditions are ours to invent.

Conversation Starters (continued)

THURSDAY — WAFFLES

"We're having breakfast for dinner! What other rules do you think would be fun to flip upside down for a day? Bedtime at noon? Parents go to school and kids go to work? What would your upside-down day look like?"

Breakfast-for-dinner is delightful precisely because it breaks a rule, and eight-year-olds are deep in the process of understanding which rules matter and which are just habits. This question lets Elsie play with rule-breaking safely, building her sense of humor and her moral reasoning at the same time.

FRIDAY — GOOD PIZZA (CLEVELAND)

"We just flew to a whole new city! When you stepped off the plane and looked around, what was the first thing you noticed that was different from home? And what was the first thing that felt the same?"

Travel sharpens observation — kids who are asked to notice details become better at reading new environments. The 'different AND same' structure teaches Elsie that new places aren't all-or-nothing scary; there's always something familiar to anchor to. This builds adaptability, a skill she'll use every time she walks into a new classroom, team, or friendship.

SATURDAY — SAVAGE BURGER (CLEVELAND)

"We've been exploring Cleveland all day. If you were writing a travel guide for other kids visiting this city, what would be your number-one must-do recommendation and your one 'skip it' warning?"

Asking Elsie to be the expert — the guide, the reviewer — flips the usual parent-child dynamic. At eight, she craves competence and being taken seriously. Framing her opinions as advice for other kids validates her perspective and builds critical thinking: she has to evaluate, rank, and justify her experience.

Nudges

The Transition Compass

Monday's house viewing is a big family moment — exciting for adults, but potentially confusing for an eight-year-old who might not fully understand what it means. Kids this age often mirror the emotions they see without understanding the source.

Before you walk into the house, give Elsie a job. Hand her your phone or a small notebook and ask her to be the family's official house reviewer — rate each room on a scale of 1-10, note what she likes, what she'd change. This transforms her from a passive bystander into an active participant with a role. After the viewing, ask for her review at dinner. Her opinions don't have to drive the decision, but being asked makes the transition feel collaborative, not imposed.

1. Before the visit, say: 'We're going to look at a house today. I want you to be our official reviewer — rate every room and tell us what you think afterward.'
 2. Give her a notebook or phone to take notes or photos during the walkthrough.
 3. At dinner (Babo Pasta), ask for her full review — listen to every rating, ask follow-up questions, and thank her for her perspective.
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The Spring Break Highlight Reel

Spring break is a rare stretch of unstructured family time, and it's easy to let the days blur together. By Thursday, Elsie might not remember what she did on Monday. Creating a simple daily ritual helps her practice reflection and gives the week a narrative arc.

Each night before bed, spend three minutes on a 'highlight reel.' Each family member shares one image from the day — not a summary, just a single snapshot moment. Elsie might say 'the pink cherry blossoms reflecting in the water' or 'when Dad made a funny face at the house.' By Saturday in Cleveland, you'll have a collection of seven snapshots that tell the story of your week together.

1. Start Sunday night after the cherry blossom visit: 'Let's try something this week — every night, each of us shares one snapshot from the day. Not the whole day, just one picture in your mind.'
 2. Go first to model it — keep yours vivid and short: 'Mine is Elsie running ahead of us on the path with petals in her hair.'
 3. On Saturday night in Cleveland, review all seven snapshots together — you'll have built a family memory album without a single photo.
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The Cleveland Co-Pilot

Flying to Cleveland on Friday is a genuine adventure, and at eight, Elsie is ready to be more than a passenger. Research shows that giving children age-appropriate responsibility during travel builds executive function, confidence, and a sense of belonging in the family unit.

Make Elsie the trip's co-pilot. Before Friday, sit down together and let her help plan one piece of the Cleveland trip — maybe she picks a park to visit, a dessert spot to try, or an activity for Saturday. Give her a real say in a real decision. On travel day, give her a small job at the airport (watching for the gate number, carrying her own boarding pass). The message: you're not just coming along — you're part of the crew.

1. Wednesday or Thursday, pull up a map of Cleveland together: 'We're going to a new city — what should we make sure we do while we're there? Pick one thing that's your choice.'
 2. At the airport, hand her the boarding passes or let her navigate to the gate using the signs.
 3. In Cleveland, follow through on her pick — and when you're there, tell her: 'This was your idea, and it's great.'
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Reflection

The Vanderbeekers of 141st Street by Karina Yan Glaser

Five siblings discover their family might lose the brownstone apartment that is the only home they've ever known — and they hatch a plan to change their grumpy landlord's mind. It's warm, funny, and packed with the specific chaos of a big-hearted family. For an eight-year-old, it's a page-turner. For a family that might be looking at a new home, it's a conversation starter about what makes a place feel like 'ours.' Elsie will see kids her age grappling with the same question she might be quietly asking: what happens when home changes?

This week you're literally walking through a door that might become home. The Vanderbeekers explores what home really means — is it the walls, the people, or the memories inside? Start reading it together this week, especially after Monday's house visit. It gives Elsie language for feelings she might not know how to name yet.

Sometime this week — maybe on the plane to Cleveland, maybe while Elsie is asleep in a hotel bed — ask yourself: when was the last time I walked through a door not knowing what was on the other side? Not a house door. A life door. A decision, a conversation, a risk. Your daughter is watching you navigate uncertainty this week — the new house, the travel, the open schedule. She's not just watching what you decide. She's watching how you decide. The calm you bring to the unknown is the same calm she'll borrow someday when she's standing in front of her own unfamiliar door. You don't have to have all the answers. You just have to keep walking through.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

The Stoic Guide

DIRECTION

Which Port Are You Sailing Toward?

Knowing where you're headed gives meaning to every wind that blows — even the ones that push against you.

"If one does not know to which port one is sailing, no wind is favorable."

— Seneca, *Moral Letters to Lucilius* 71.3

The cherry blossoms are out at the Tidal Basin. You stood among them on Sunday — petals drifting, crowds murmuring, your daughter craning her neck toward branches heavy with pink. It was beautiful, and it was already ending. That is the mood of this week: beauty in motion, life asking you where you're headed. This week your family considers a new home. You'll sit in a house that isn't yours yet and imagine a future there. You'll pack bags for Cleveland and leave one place for another. These are acts of direction — choosing which port to sail toward, as Seneca put it. The Stoics knew that without a clear aim, even favorable winds are wasted. But they also knew that the aim need not be a destination on a map. The truest direction is internal: Who am I becoming? What kind of life am I building? Direction doesn't mean certainty. It means intention. The cherry blossoms don't know when they'll fall, but they open anyway — fully, without reservation. That's the practice this week: open fully toward what matters, even when the future is uncertain.

SUNDAY The Petals at the Basin

You saw the cherry blossoms today. Thousands of people came to see something that will be gone in days. That's not sad — it's clarifying. When something is brief, you pay attention. You notice. Direction begins with noticing: where you are, what you have, what is already beautiful and already leaving.

What in your life right now is beautiful because it won't last? Write it down. One thing.

"Think of yourself as dead. You have lived your life. Now, take what's left and live it properly." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 7.56

MONDAY The Question the House Asks

This afternoon you'll walk through a house and imagine your family inside it. Rooms will feel right or wrong. A yard will seem big enough or too small. But the real question isn't about the house — it's about the life you want to build. Every big decision is an act of direction. The Stoics didn't say "have no preferences." They said: know what you're choosing, and why.

Before the house visit, each person writes one sentence: "The most important thing about where we live is ____."
Compare notes at dinner.

"Let all your efforts be directed to something, let it keep that end in view." — Seneca, Moral Letters to Lucilius 52.3

Reflections & Practice

TUESDAY The Current Beneath

Your daughter is in the pool tonight, learning to trust the water. Swimming is an act of direction through resistance — you move forward not by fighting the current but by working with it. Epictetus taught that we waste energy struggling against what we can't control. Real direction means putting your effort where it counts: your stroke, your breath, your form.

Where in your life are you fighting the current instead of swimming with it? Name one thing you could stop resisting. "First say to yourself what you would be; and then do what you have to do." — Epictetus, Discourses 3.23.1

WEDNESDAY The Art of the Simple Day

Pizza night. No agenda. The Stoics would approve — not because they valued laziness, but because they understood that an uncluttered day reveals what you actually care about. When there's nowhere you have to be, where do you drift? That drift is data. It shows you what your internal compass points toward when no one else is steering.

At the end of today, notice what you did when you didn't have to do anything. Was it toward connection? Solitude? Play? Creation? That's a clue about your direction.

THURSDAY The Open Field

A free day in the middle of spring break is a rare gift. Marcus Aurelius warned against filling time with busyness that has no purpose. Today, try the opposite: choose one thing deliberately. Not from obligation. Not from habit. From intention. One meal, one walk, one conversation — chosen because it matters.

Choose one activity today purely because it aligns with what you value. Before you begin, say out loud or silently: "I am choosing this."

"It is not that we have a short space of time, but that we waste much of it." — Seneca, On the Shortness of Life 1.3

Reflections & Practice

FRIDAY What You Carry

You're flying to Cleveland today, which means packing — deciding what comes with you and what stays behind. Travel is a physical metaphor for direction: you literally choose what to carry. The Stoics practiced this as a discipline of mind. What thoughts, worries, and expectations are you packing? Which ones can you leave at home?

As you pack, notice one worry or expectation you're carrying into the trip. Write it on a scrap of paper and leave it on your nightstand. You can pick it up when you get back — if you still want it.

"We suffer more in imagination than in reality." — Seneca, Moral Letters to Lucilius 13.4

SATURDAY Arrival Is Not the Point

You're in Cleveland. A different city, different beds, different rhythms. But here's the Stoic insight: arrival is never the point. The port Seneca spoke of isn't a place you reach — it's a way you travel. You can be lost in your own living room and perfectly oriented in a strange city, if your inner compass is calibrated. Direction is not where you are. It's who you are, wherever you are.

In this new place, take five minutes alone. Close your eyes. Ask: "Am I pointed toward what matters?" Let the answer come without forcing it.

Practice Together

The Compass Question

At one meal this week — any meal — go around the table and each person answers: “What is one thing that matters to you more now than it did a year ago?” No right answers. No judgment. Just listen. Then notice: are your compasses pointing in similar directions, or different ones? Both are fine. The point is to know.

Seneca believed that most people drift through life without examining their aims. This exercise is a family version of his challenge: name your port.

The Map in Your Head

Imagine you have a treasure map, but instead of gold, the treasure is the best day you can think of. What's on it? Who's there? What are you doing? Now here's the secret: you don't need the map to be perfect. You just need to know which direction to walk. If your best day has your family in it, walk toward your family. If it has swimming in it, keep swimming. You already know your direction — you just have to trust it.

The Stoics said that having a direction — even a wobbly one — is better than wandering. You don't have to have everything figured out. You just have to know what matters to you, and take one step that way.

The cherry blossoms didn't ask for more time. They opened toward the sun and gave everything they had. That's direction enough.

Bedtime Story

The Tale of the Cherry Blossoms

The Tale of the Cherry Blossoms

Papa Puleo and Mamma Karen walked slowly along the Tidal Basin on a morning so still that the water held the sky like a mirror. Pink petals drifted past them in the spring breeze, catching the light before settling on the path like confetti from a celebration no one had thrown.

"You know," Papa Puleo said, resting his hand on the gnarled bark of an old Yoshino cherry tree, "someday we'll bring little Chelsie here. And we'll tell her the whole story."

Mamma Karen smiled. "Then we'd better practice."

Papa Puleo drew a slow breath. The blossoms smelled faintly sweet, like honey left open near a window. "It started with a gift," he began. "In 1912, the mayor of Tokyo — a man named Yukio Ozaki — sent three thousand cherry trees across the ocean to Washington. Three thousand! Can you imagine, Karen? All those little trees on a ship, sailing for weeks."

"A gift of friendship," Mamma Karen said softly. "Between two nations."

"That's right. And when they arrived, the First Lady herself — Helen Taft — planted the very first one, right here along this water. March twenty-seventh, 1912. She knelt in the mud in her nice dress and pressed the roots into the ground." He chuckled. "I like to think she didn't care one bit about the mud."

Mamma Karen touched a low branch, letting the petals brush her fingers. "In Japan, they call these sakura. The blossoms mean something beautiful and a little sad — that nothing lasts forever, but that makes it precious. Every spring they bloom, and every spring they fall, and people gather just to watch."

"That's what I want Chelsie to know," Papa Puleo said quietly. He pressed his palm flat against the trunk. The bark was rough and cool, ridged like a map of all the years the tree had stood. "That someone once cared enough to send beauty across an ocean. That a woman knelt in the dirt to plant it. That the trees kept growing, year after year, even when the world was hard."

They walked on. The path curved, and more trees arched above them, their branches heavy with blossoms that glowed pale pink against the blue sky.

"Let's leave something here for her," Mamma Karen whispered. "Not a note. Not a thing. Just — us. Our words. Our love. Right here among these branches."

Papa Puleo nodded. "Then when she touches this bark someday, maybe she'll feel it. Maybe she'll know."

And they kept walking and talking, pressing their hands to every trunk, speaking softly of history and hope and a granddaughter who would one day stand exactly where they stood.

• • •

Years later, on a morning just as still, a girl named Chelsie walked the same path.

The cherry blossoms were in full bloom. Petals spiraled around her sneakers. She reached out and pressed her hand flat against the trunk of an old, gnarled tree — the bark rough and cool beneath her fingers.

And then she heard it.

Faint. Like a breeze that carried words instead of wind.

"...three thousand trees across the ocean..."

Chelsie held her breath.

"...sakura... nothing lasts forever, but that makes it precious..."

She leaned closer, her ear against the bark.

"...someday we'll bring little Chelsie here..."

She pulled back, heart racing, and looked up into the branches. Pink petals floated down like whispered secrets. She didn't understand it all. But she understood enough.

Someone had loved her here, long before she arrived.

And the trees had remembered.

Is there a special place where your family has shared stories or made memories? What do you think those places remember about you?

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